Bajpayee—in his blink-and-you-miss-it role—had barely shown up for two or three sessions. Khan played an unnamed, queer-coded senior student.

Krishen is happy *Annie* has been resurrected. "[In 2024], I was about to throw it (the 16 mm films) all away because it was junk from my past life," he says. It was exactly then, rather serendipitously, that a friend was visiting him. Said friend put him in touch with Shivendra Singh Dungarpur of the Film Heritage Foundation. A couple of days later, Dungarpur flew down to Delhi to meet Krishen and acquire the film for restoration.

It took a year and a half in Italy's L'Immagine Ritrovata laboratory to piece *Annie* back together. There was no way Dungarpur would have passed on this opportunity. "I mean, they were making anti-state films with state money, and there were no issues," Dungarpur says. "Today, the big challenge is that independent cinema in India doesn't exist, in terms of funding or everything else. So, as a restorer, I knew this needed to be seen in theatres," he says, adding that once *Annie* returns from its Berlin getaway, it'll have screenings in Delhi, Mumbai and other metros. Until then, *Annie* will continue to be discovered by new film nerds in its spirit of "giving it those ones", which, back in the day, meant "to do one's usual sh*t". ■

—Arshia

CINEMA ▼

Finding **Her Frame**

ACTOR MALAVIKA MOHANAN, WHOSE LATEST RELEASE IS *THE RAJASAAB*, HAS CHOSEN COMPELLING STORIES OVER SAFE STARDOM

The first person to tell Malavika Mohanan that she should be an actor was not her father, renowned cinematographer K. Mohanan, but an actor by the name of Aamir Khan. Malavika, who was still in college and visiting the sets of *Talaash* (shot by her father), recalls being flattered, but moved on. She'd apply to FTII's editing course, but wouldn't get through. Mohanan is glad it didn't work out because next time another superstar actor, Mammootty, would straight up offer her a leading role in a Malayalam film (*Pattam Pole* in 2013).

Mohanan has acted in Malayalam, Tamil and Telugu films, but what earned her most adulation is ***HRIDAYAPOORVAM***, where she was cast against Mohanlal



PTI

Raised and based in Mumbai, Mohanan grew up on an eclectic diet of films. In the process, she imbibed many lessons. "You need to know what the film expects out of you, be it a hyperrealist or a massy one," she says. Her own career thus far shows she likes to mix things up, doing a Pa Ranjith film (*Thangaalan*) and then picking a horror comedy opposite Prabhas (*The RajaSaab*). But the film that has earned her most adulation, particularly in her home state Kerala, is *Hridayapoorvam* (2025), her first opposite another superstar, Mohanlal.

"For me, more than being starstruck, it was surreal because my earliest memory of watching cinema is films of Mohanlal and Mammooty," says Mohanan. "It was also intimidating because he is a one-take actor and I take a couple of takes to get in rhythm." Mohanan rehearsed the scenes with the associate director and pulled them off in a single take.

While Mohanan has dabbled across languages in Malayalam, Tamil and Telugu, her best-known Hindi credit is Iranian filmmaker Majid Majidi's India-set *Beyond the Clouds*. It's not that she has had a dearth of offers. "Lots have come my way, but if I don't connect with it, I am not doing it," she says. If a call does come from Kiran Rao, Vishal Bhardwaj, Vikramaditya Motwane or Zoya Akhtar, Mohanan would be game. "I am drawn to filmmakers whose vision I can surrender to and who will get the best out of me," she says. "When I started off, I wanted to work with big actors. Now I know what sustains you is good films and memorable characters." ■

—Suhani Singh